

AIR & SPACE FORCES MAGAZINE





Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you’ve provided to them or that they’ve collected from your use of their services.

OK

RQ-4 Global Hawk

The Global Hawk is a strategic long-endurance, high-altitude, “deep look” ISR platform complementing satellite and manned ISR.

The system consists of the aircraft and sensors, launch and recovery element (LRE), mission control element (MCE), and comms/ mission planning cell. 



The preproduction Block 10 debuted in combat in 2001 and retired in 2011. The follow-on Block 20 was initially equipped with the Enhanced Integrated Sensor Suite (EISS) for imagery intelligence (IMINT) and five were eventually converted as EQ-4B Battlefield Airborne Communications Node (BACN) relays, retired in 2021.



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you've provided to them or that they've collected from your use of their services.

alongside C-27B supporting operations in the EUCOM area of operations, in addition to testing concepts for Arctic surveillance.

RQ-4 Global Hawk Technical Data

Contractors: Northrop Grumman, Raytheon, L3Harris.

First Flight: Feb. 28, 1998.

Delivered: August 2003-present.

IOC: August 2011 (Block 30); August 2016 (Block 40).

Production: 45 (USAF).
Inventory: 9 (Block 40).
Operator: ACC, AFMC.
Aircraft Location: Beale AFB, Calif. (Block 30); Edwards AFB, Calif.; Grand Forks AFB, N.D. (Block 20/40); forward operating locations: Ali Al Salem AB, Kuwait (EQ-4B); Andersen AFB, Guam; NAS Sigonella, Italy; Yokota AB, Japan.
Active Variants: •EQ-4B Block 20. Battlefield Airborne Communications Node (BACN) comm relay platform. •RQ-4B Block 30. Multi-intelligence platform equipped with EO/IR and SAR sensors. •RQ-4B Block 40. AESA and SAR equipped ground moving target indication (GMTI) and battlefield ISR platform.
Dimensions: Span 130.9 ft, length 47.6 ft, height 15.3 ft.
Weight: Max T-O 32 250 lb; max payload 3 000 lb



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you’ve provided to them or that they’ve collected from your use of their services.

US Hits Iranian Boats, Missile Sites; Iran Claims Drone Shootdown

May 26, 2026 | By Chris Gordon

Strategy & Policy: Telling USAF’s Story is a Critical Mission

Feb. 6, 2026 | By John A. Tirpak

WORLD: History

Sept. 12, 2025

Drone Hype and Airpower Amnesia

July 25, 2025 | By Lt. Col. Grant Georgulis, USAF

Lawmakers Urge Air Force, SOCOM to Collaborate on New Long-Range Surveillance Drones

June 23, 2025 | By Rachel S. Cohen



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you’ve provided to them or that they’ve collected from your use of their services.

USAF Experiments with Drones to Better Monitor Russia in the Arctic

Sept. 18, 2024 | By Unshin Lee Harpley

NORAD Boss ‘Intrigued’ by New High-Altitude Drones Amid Increase in Russian Approaches

Sept. 17, 2024 | By Unshin Lee Harpley

In a First, USAF RQ-4 Global Hawk to Operate from UK

Aug. 23, 2024 | By John A. Tirpak

F-35s Lead 50 USAF Aircraft in NATO Air Defense Exercise

May 10, 2024 | By Chris Gordon and Unshin Lee Harpley

Getting Ready for the New Test Surge



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you've provided to them or that they've collected from your use of their services.

Northrop Won't Bid on Air Force's NGAD Fighter, But CCA, F/A-XX Programs Still in Play

July 27, 2023 | By John A. Tirpak

World: Space

June 22, 2023

USAF Looks to Fill Intelligence Gaps from Space

May 17, 2023 | By Greg Hadley

The Future Force

March 31, 2023 | By John A. Tirpak



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you've provided to them or that they've collected from your use of their services.

Dec. 2, 2022 | By Heather Penney

Austin: Need to Consider 'Range of Capabilities' in Developing Hypersonic Weapons

May 3, 2022 | By Greg Hadley

RQ-4 Pilot and Instructor Faulted in Crash that Destroyed \$64 Million Drone

April 25, 2022 | By Greg Hadley

2022 Will Be a Big Year for USAF

Jan. 21, 2022 | By John A. Tirpak

RQ-4 Global Hawk Drone Crashes in North Dakota

Aug. 6, 2021 | By Greg Hadley



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you've provided to them or that they've collected from your use of their services.

Global Hawk Learns New Tricks While Congress Mulls Retirement

Aug. 13, 2020 | By Rachel S. Cohen

Air Force to Continue 'Zero-Based' Budget Reviews

Aug. 3, 2020 | By Rachel S. Cohen

Oil Leak, Improper Mission Planning Caused 2018 RQ-4 Crash

July 20, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

World

July 1, 2020 | By Air & Space Forces Magazine Staff

HASC Floats Modest Modernization, New Sustainment Jobs



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you've provided to them or that they've collected from your use of their services.

Goldfein on How USAF Is Generating Airpower in the 'New Abnormal'

April 15, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

CENTCOM, AFRICOM Urge Lawmakers Not to Cut MQ-9, Combat Air Patrols

March 10, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine and Rachel S. Cohen

Goldfein Defends USAF Decision to Retire Legacy Aircraft

March 4, 2020 | By Amy Hudson

World

March 1, 2020 | By Air & Space Forces Magazine Staff

Goldfein: Take Risk Now to Buy Future Capability



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you've provided to them or that they've collected from your use of their services.

Legacy Fleets Take Hit to Pay for RDT&E Funding Boost

Feb. 10, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

DOD Budget Invests in Space, Nuclear Modernization, Multi-Domain Operations

Feb. 10, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

The Bone is Back

Feb. 1, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

NATO Receives First Air Ground Surveillance Aircraft

Jan. 17, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

Congress Looks to Bolster USAF Drone Development in 2020



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you've provided to them or that they've collected from your use of their services.

New Global Hawk Wing Charts Path to Maturity

Oct. 15, 2019 | By Rachel S. Cohen

USAF Portfolio Expands in Libya Operation

March 29, 2011

Air & Space Forces Magazine is the official publication of the Air & Space Forces Association, 1201 S. Joyce St., C6 /
Second Fl., Arlington, Va., 22202. Copyright 2026



Consent

Details

About

This website uses cookies

We use cookies to personalize content and ads, to provide social media features and to analyze our traffic. We also share information about your use of our site with our social media, advertising and analytics partners who may combine it with other information that you've provided to them or that they've collected from your use of their services.